

Storytelling - Building capacity: starting small and growing together

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- Let me take you back to **where reporting began in the European Environment Agency**.
- Some of this goes back to before I joined the Agency, but **I strongly feel part of the institutional continuum** and the work it sustains.
- When the Agency first became responsible for this work, what we had **was very small**. Just three people working on climate and energy reporting.
- This was in the 1990s.
- At that time, the work to do was limited. **Quite technical**.
- Then slowly, in the 2000s, the requirements progressively increased and therefore the team grew.
- By the 2010s, the situation had changed a lot. We were doing more reporting. More analysis. **More coordination was necessary**.
- But still, we were not a “system”. We were a group of people trying to keep up.

The challenge

- The **EU Governance Regulation (2018/1999)** introduced a common framework to plan, monitor, and coordinate climate and energy policies across all EU Member States.
- The **National Energy and Climate Plans (NECPs)** were introduced, and each country must prepare 10-year plans explaining how it will contribute to EU climate and energy targets.
- Also, a **continuous governance cycle with planning, reporting, EU review, and policy adjustment in an iterative process was new**.
- A stronger focus on **harmonised reporting and monitoring** also came with the revision.
- Further the **integration of climate and energy policy** was introduced bringing together the five dimensions (decarbonisation, efficiency, energy security, internal market, innovation) in one framework.
- Overall, the Regulation created the **operational system that ensures the EU and its Member States collectively deliver on the 2030 climate targets and the Paris Agreement**.
- Put in short: before, climate and energy were handled in separate streams. **After the regulation, they had to be integrated**.
- This **sounds simple, but it was not**.

- Due to the developments over the course of two decades we were at a stage where we had:
 - More data
 - More reporting requirements
 - More expectations
 - And more complexity
- So we faced an important question:

How do you build capacity when the work grows faster than your team?

- We asked for more resources.
- But we did not get everything we asked for. So, we had to find another way.

What we learned

- At the beginning, we tried to organise the work in a very simple way. **Each person had one task. One responsibility.**
- This felt efficient. But it created a problem.
- If one person was absent, or left, we lost knowledge. And the system became fragile.
- So, we changed our approach. **Instead of** building a team of specialists in **silos**, we started to create **overlap**.
- We asked people to work across different areas.

For example:

- One person worked on both policies and projections
- Another worked across renewable energy and efficiency
- Sometimes they did not like it at first. But something important happened.
- They began to see connections. They understood how the different pieces fit together.
- **And this created something very valuable:**
- **Resilience.** Not just technical capacity, but team resilience.

A second breakthrough

- Then we realised something else. **Capacity is not only about what happens inside** your organisation.
- It also depends on what happens **outside**.
- **We work with many partners:**
 - Ministries
 - Sector experts
 - National authorities
- They all provide data. They all have knowledge.
- So, **we needed to support them and we started organising:**
 - Training sessions
 - Webinars
 - Open support meetings
- We **helped people understand:**
 - How to report
 - Where to click
 - How to solve errors
- These small things **made a big difference**. Because we were not just collecting data anymore.
- We were building a **network**. And this network made the whole system stronger. And this is the network you can **tap into for guidance** today while building your own reporting capacity

Challenges along the way

- Of course, it was not always easy. This kind of work is very specialised.
- **Some people like to go deep into technical details**. Others want to work **more broadly**. Not everyone can do everything.

For example:

- Some people are good at data
- Some are good at writing and explaining
- Some want to do both
- Balancing these skills is a challenge.

- Also, at the beginning, you need people who can do many things. Like a **“Swiss army knife”**.
- But over time, **you must organise the work better**. And that transition can be difficult.

Where we are today

- Today, we are in a very different place.
- We have:
 - **A larger team** (11 in-house plus 6 in the ETCs with some overlap)
 - Stronger IT support
 - And a wide network of partners
- We are **still learning**. We are still improving. But we now have a system that works.

The key lesson

- So what is the main lesson from this story? It is very simple.
- **You do not need to be perfect on day one.**
- In fact, if you wait for perfection, you will never start.
- The standards are very high. They will always be higher than what you can do at the beginning.
- So instead of waiting until you have the perfect reporting scheme:
 - Start with the data you have
 - Build step by step
 - Improve over time
 - Connect people and knowledge
- Because capacity is not something you build once.
- It is something you build continuously.

Final reflection

- And maybe the most important part is this:
- At some point, people realise that their work is not just technical.
- **They are contributing to something bigger.**

- They are contributing to better decisions on how to cut green house gas emission in Europe and ensure lower energy bills for the Europeans through the transition to renewable energy production.
- **That sense of purpose is what really builds capacity in the long term.**
- Thank you